

Conversational Roles of Side Characters in *The Office (US)*: A Topic Analysis of Jan, Oscar, Angela, and Toby

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Introduction

In this project, we examined the dialogue of four side characters from *The Office (US)* (Jan, Oscar, Angela, and Toby) to determine the topics that each character tends to discuss and how much attention each character devotes to these topics. By addressing these questions, our analysis offers a structured understanding of character specific conversational roles, which is valuable for the production company interested in character development and narrative dynamics.

To achieve this, we examined the dialogue of the interested side characters using a combination of manual annotation and computational text analysis. Our study identified six major topics: Humour and Sarcasm, Personal Life and Relationships, HR/Legal/Workplace Policies, Workplace Logistics, Interpersonal Relationships, and Opinions/Reactions/Personal Commentary. The findings reveal clear distinctions in how each character contributes to the series. Jan’s dialogue alternates between professional HR concerns and emotional topics, reflecting her dual role as a corporate executive and as a character with personal storylines. Angela emphasizes Workplace Logistics and Personal Life, highlighting her role as head of accounting with a highly organized and judgemental personality. Toby blends Humour and HR-related discussions, consistent with his position as an HR representative who often provides subtle comedic relief. Oscar distributes his dialogue more evenly across topics, serving as a socially aware and reflective presence within the office.

Overall, these results demonstrate that side characters are assigned deliberate conversational roles that shape humour, interpersonal dynamics, and narrative flow, illustrating the distinct contributions of each character to the series.

Data

Our custom dataset draws on a publicly available script dataset from *The Office (US)* obtained through the Kaggle API

(Kaggle, n.d.). We downloaded this dataset as the foundation of our analysis. “The Office (US) Complete Dialogue/Transcript” from Kaggle contains full episode-level transcripts including speaker labels and individual lines, totaling just over 54,600 entries (nasirkhalid24, n.d.). From this corpus, we extracted dialogue for the four side characters selected for analysis: Jan, Oscar, Angela, and Toby. Using the structured speaker labels in the transcript, we filtered the dataset to retain only lines spoken by these characters. To ensure that our dataset contained substantive dialogue, we first removed lines containing fewer than three words. This decision excluded short lines (e.g. “yeah”, “okay”, “right”), which do not meaningfully contribute to topic identification and would otherwise bias TF-IDF score toward conversational noise. As a second filtering step, we manually reviewed the remaining lines and removed trivial or contextless dialogue to improve the quality of the dataset. After preprocessing, the resulting dataset contained 1779 non-trivial lines across the four characters: Jan (399 lines), Oscar (487 lines), Angela (496 lines), and Toby (397 lines). These totals exceed the project requirement of at least 300 meaningful lines per character and provide a sufficiently large and balanced dataset for topic development, manual annotation, and subsequent computational analysis.

Methods

Our analysis consisted of three major components: topic development, manual annotation, and computational characterization. While the project guidelines outline the overall analytical pipeline, several additional design decisions influenced the structure and outcomes of our results.

Topic Development:

To construct meaningful and consistent topic categories, we conducted open coding on 100 lines from each character and constrained each speech act to exactly one topic. We decided to collectively begin with a general set of categories and with every iteration of open coding, we merged or split categories when they produced overlapping boundaries or inconsistent assignments. We aimed to ensure that the topics

were neither too broad (which would obscure important distinctions) nor too narrow (which would produce sparse categories and unreliable TF-IDF results). We ultimately converged on six well-defined topics: (1) Humour and Sarcasm, (2) Personal Life and Relationships, (3) HR/Legal/Workplace Policies, (4) Workplace Logistics, (5) Interpersonal Relationships, (6) Opinions/Reactions/Personal Commentary. This iterative refinement was essential for generating topic categories that produced interpretable and discriminative TF-IDF profiles.

Manual Annotation:

After finalizing the topic schema, all 1779 lines were manually annotated by all three group members. We followed the accepted annotation practice in which each speech act is independently labeled by three annotators, ensuring higher reliability than single-pass coding. Each member received the full dataset and used the shared annotation guidelines we developed, which outlined topic definitions, explanations, and examples. Once all annotations were completed, we applied a majority-vote procedure to determine the final label for each line. In cases where all three annotators disagreed, we conducted a brief adjudication discussion and resolved disagreements by consensus. This multi-annotator strategy greatly reduced individual bias, improved topic consistency, and helped ensure that each category reflected a stable and reproducible interpretation of the underlying dialogue. These choices directly strengthened the validity of the topic frequencies and improved the stability of downstream comparisons across characters.

Text Preprocessing and Feature Extraction:

To characterize topics computationally, we applied TF-IDF analysis to the text within each category as instructed. A major design choice was the construction of an expanded custom stop word list tailored to dialogue from *The Office*. Standard English stop words were insufficient because character speech contains many filler expressions (“oh”, “yeah”, “really”) and dialogue-specific verbal habits (“look”, “think”, “want”) that appeared frequently across all categories but provided not meaningful signal. We also removed character names to prevent them from artificially dominating certain topics simply due to conversational address patterns. These preprocessing decisions resulted in more meaningful TF-IDF rankings by suppressing dialogue noise and allowing topic-specific vocabulary to emerge more clearly.

Results

Our analysis of the dialogue from side characters in the selected TV series revealed six major topical categories: HR, Humour, Interpersonal Relationships, Logistics, Opinions/Reactions, and Personal Life & Relationships. These

categories were developed through open coding of the dialogue and characterized using both the top TF-IDF words, their associated TF-IDF scores, and representative summaries generated by a large language model. In constructing these categories, we ignored all words that did not contribute to understanding the typology, such as common stop words, filler words, and character-specific names, ensuring that the analysis focuses on terms that meaningfully differentiate the categories. The results demonstrate how each character engages with different aspects of the workplace and personal life, highlighting the distribution and focus of conversation across themes. In addition to numerical summaries, we present bar plots of the real TF-IDF scores for the top 10 words in each category (Figures 1–6), which provide a visual representation of the relative importance of these terms within each topical category.

The HR (Human Resources / Workplace Policy) category encompasses dialogue related to corporate rules, workplace conduct, HR procedures, and legal concerns, including hiring, firing, and behavioral review. Words such as “company” (11 occurrences, 0.49%), “hr” (9 occurrences, 0.40%), “branch” (6 occurrences, 0.27%), and “fired” (6 occurrences, 0.27%) appear frequently, with additional mentions of “corporate,” “offer,” “policy,” “lawyer,” “behavior,” and “review.” These counts suggest that characters often discuss structured workplace matters, emphasizing formal decision-making and organizational oversight. The LLM-generated summary reinforces this interpretation, highlighting that conversations in this category revolve around policy-heavy discussions, HR processes, and legal considerations. The corresponding TF-IDF score bar plot (Figure 1) visualizes the relative weighting of these key terms, demonstrating the prominence of formal workplace vocabulary. In practice, this category provides insight into the professional responsibilities and compliance-related aspects that characters focus on, reflecting a formal and procedural tone in their dialogue.

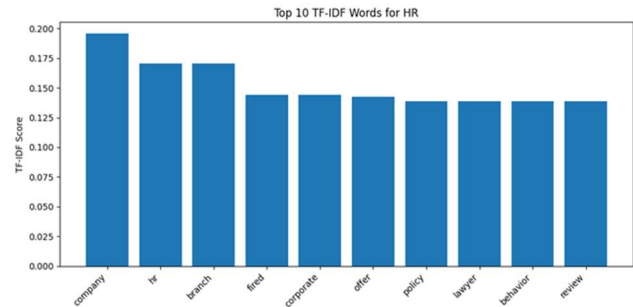


Figure 1: Most Relevant HR/Legal/Workplace Policies Words

The Humour category captures playful, comedic, or absurd dialogue, including jokes, teasing, storytelling, and humorous remarks. Notably, words like “baby” (6 occurrences, 0.21%), “help” (5 occurrences, 0.17%), and “god”

(5 occurrences, 0.17%) dominate the vocabulary, alongside “pies,” “queen,” “princess,” “weirdo,” “sleeping,” “caterer,” and “blake,” each appearing 3–4 times. The distribution of these words suggests that humor is frequently used to entertain or lighten situations, often through exaggeration, quirky characterizations, or unexpected references. According to the LLM summary, Humour lines provide playful relief and highlight eccentricities in characters’ personalities. The TF-IDF score bar plot for this category (Figure 2) further emphasizes which words contribute most strongly to the humorous dialogue, illustrating the uneven weighting among the top terms. The interplay of humorous vocabulary with context-specific references such as “caterer” or “blake” demonstrates the use of humor to both comment on events and create character-driven comedic moments.

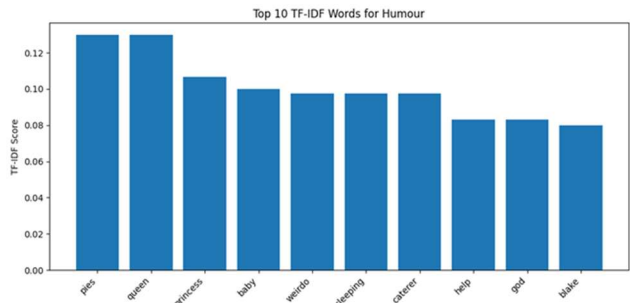


Figure 2: Most Relevant Humour and Sarcasm Words

Interpersonal Relationships focus on dialogue about social dynamics, emotional states, and workplace relationships, excluding personal romantic or intimate content. This category is dominated by words such as “feel” (7 occurrences, 0.14%), “son” (6 occurrences, 0.12%), “senator” (6 occurrences, 0.12%), and “worth” (6 occurrences, 0.12%), with other key terms including “calling,” “thinking,” “help,” “stressed,” “talking,” and “phyllis.” These counts suggest that characters frequently engage in emotionally oriented conversations and interpersonal exchanges. The LLM summary emphasizes that this category highlights concern, support, and social obligations within workplace or social interactions.

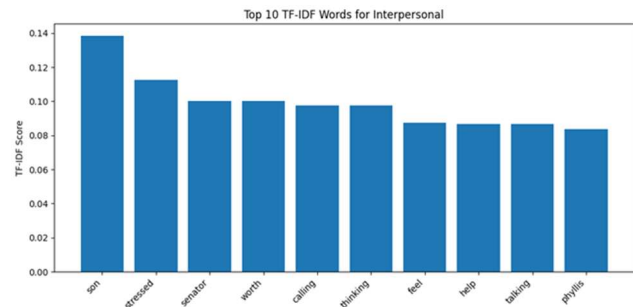


Figure 3: Most Relevant Interpersonal Relationships Words

The corresponding TF-IDF bar plot (Figure 3) illustrates the relative prominence of these terms, providing a quantitative view of how different words signal relational dialogue. These conversations offer insight into characters’ relational priorities, revealing how side characters navigate stress, responsibilities, and emotional engagement with peers or acquaintances.

The Logistics category represents practical, operational dialogue about scheduling, event planning, task assignments, and organizational coordination. Words such as “party” (22 occurrences, 0.31%), “office” (17 occurrences, 0.24%), “work” (14 occurrences, 0.19%), and “branch” (13 occurrences, 0.18%) are most prominent, while “hour,” “corporate,” “planning,” “committee,” “board,” and “miffin” also appear with notable frequency. These counts indicate that much of the dialogue in this category is task-focused and operational, reflecting characters’ engagement with planning and coordination within the workplace. The LLM summary reinforces this interpretation, highlighting that Logistics discussions revolve around scheduling, event organization, office operations, and committee work. The TF-IDF score bar plot (Figure 4) highlights which operational terms are most influential in defining this category. This category captures the structured, process-driven aspects of dialogue that maintain organizational functionality.

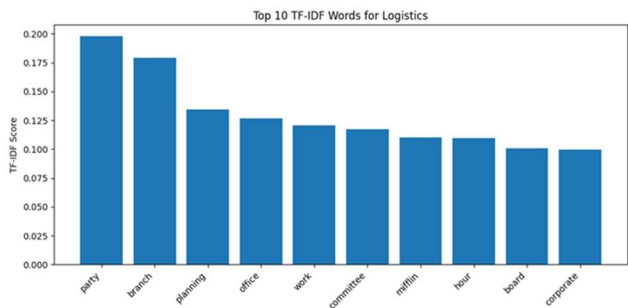


Figure 4: Most Relevant Workplace Logistics Words

The Opinions/Reactions category contains subjective dialogue including personal preferences, emotional reactions, and casual commentary. Dominant words include “nope” (11 occurrences, 0.36%), “people” (11 occurrences, 0.36%), “better” (8 occurrences, 0.26%), “kind” (7 occurrences, 0.23%), and “hot” (5 occurrences, 0.16%), complemented by “art,” “angry,” “deserves,” “coincidence,” and “fun.” These word counts suggest that characters frequently voice judgments or emotional responses, reflecting attitudes, likes, dislikes, and evaluations of people or situations. According to the LLM summary, this category showcases how personal viewpoints and reactions are expressed through dialogue, revealing individual personality traits, humor, and social attitudes. The TF-IDF bar plot for this category (Figure 5) provides a visual summary of the words most strongly

associated with evaluative or reactive language. This category is particularly useful for understanding the subjective lens through which side characters interpret events and interactions.

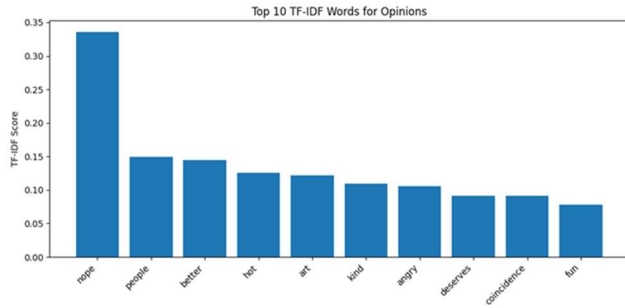


Figure 5: Most Relevant Opinions/Reactions/Personal Commentary Words

Finally, the Personal Life & Relationships category captures dialogue about romantic relationships, family, pets, personal history, identity, and emotional experiences. Key words include “gay” (25 occurrences, 0.29%), “senator” (23 occurrences, 0.27%), “love” (13 occurrences, 0.15%), “cat” (14 occurrences, 0.16%), and “wanted” (14 occurrences, 0.16%), as well as “wife,” “husband,” “sprinkles,” “wedding,” and “knew.” The high frequency of these terms indicates that characters often engage in discussions about intimate or private aspects of their lives. The LLM summary suggests that this category provides insight into personal relationships, emotional depth, and individual backstory, offering a window into characters’ identities and motivations beyond their professional roles. The TF-IDF score bar plot (Figure 6) emphasizes which personal-life words contribute most strongly to this category. Dialogue in this category reveals facets of side characters’ private worlds, demonstrating the narrative significance of personal context in shaping interactions.

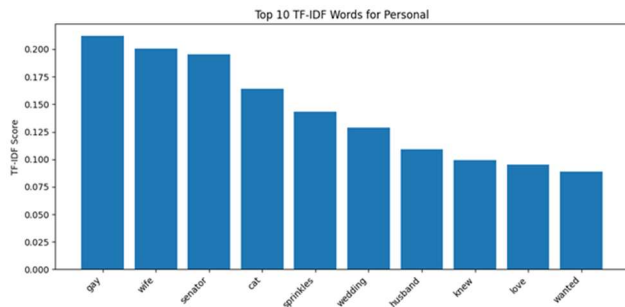


Figure 6: Most Relevant Personal Life and Relationships Words

The following stacked bar plot of topic distribution per character (Figure 7) illustrates the variability in focus across characters, showing how each side character prioritizes certain themes over others. While some characters devote more

dialogue to operational matters or policy (HR and Logistics), others emphasize personal experiences or humor. By examining word counts, percentages, and TF-IDF scores, alongside the TF-IDF bar plots, we gain a comprehensive understanding of conversational patterns, topical emphasis, and engagement across all six typologies. Overall, these results highlight how side characters contribute distinct perspectives, balancing work, social, personal, and humorous interactions to enrich the narrative.

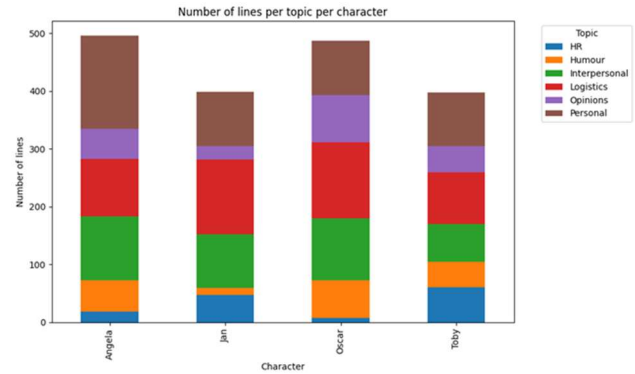


Figure 7: Topic Division of Each Character

Discussion

The topic profiles and TF IDF analyses across the four characters reveal that *The Office* assigns each side character a distinct conversational role rather than distributing dialogue themes evenly. These differences provide insight into how each character is portrayed within the series and how the narrative positions them socially and emotionally.

The most striking divergence appears in characters whose dialogue sits at the extremes of professional versus personal subject matter. Jan’s contribution is broadly divided between HR and Legal and Workplace Policies and Personal Life and Relationships. The HR category contains structured vocabulary such as “company”, “hr”, “branch”, and “fired”. The Personal Life and Relationships category contains emotionally and relationally loaded terms including “love”, “senator”, “gay”, “cat”, and “wanted”. This contrast suggests that Jan’s role is defined by movement between professional authority and emotionally charged personal storylines. Her interactions oscillate between control and vulnerability. This implies that the show uses Jan to create tension at the intersection of workplace structure and personal turbulence.

Angela shows a different combination of personal and workplace focus. Her dialogue is heavily concentrated in Workplace Logistics and Personal Life and Relationships. The Logistics category contains terms such as “party”, “office”, “work”, and “committee”, which supports her identity as someone deeply invested in rules, task management, and organization. The Personal Life and Relationships category

contains terms such as “cat”, “senator”, and “sprinkles”. These results reflect how Angela’s personal worldview is similarly rigid and value driven. The consistency between both domains suggests that Angela is written as someone whose strict standards and moral expectations shape her interpersonal conflicts inside and outside the workplace.

Toby’s topic distribution places him at the intersection of Humour and Sarcasm and HR and Legal and Workplace Policies. Humour related vocabulary such as “baby”, “help”, and “god” reflects light and understated comedic expression. Policy related terms such as “company”, “behavior”, and “review” reflect administrative responsibility. The combination of these two categories aligns with the recurring tension in Toby’s character. He is responsible for enforcing workplace policies while also trying to connect socially through soft humour that does not receive much acknowledgment from others. These patterns suggest that Toby functions as a mediator rather than a generator of dramatic conflict. His humour attempts to reduce tension rather than escalate events.

Oscar demonstrates a more evenly distributed engagement across topics. He contributes substantially to Interpersonal Relationships and to Opinions and Reactions. Interpersonal vocabulary such as “feel”, “son”, “worth”, and “stressed” reflects emotionally oriented dialogue. Opinions and Reactions vocabulary such as “nope”, “better”, “kind”, and “hot” reflects frequent evaluative commentary. This suggests that Oscar’s role is not to initiate dramatic events but to interpret them and respond to other characters. Dialogue that blends social awareness with personal judgment positions Oscar as a reflective presence rather than a chaotic or controlling one.

Group Member Contributions

Diana Covaci: question definition phase, data collection phase, open coding, data annotation phase, and the writing of the report.

Nara Yun: question definition phase, data collection, open coding, data annotation, and writing of the report.

Hanjing Zheng: question definition phase, open coding, data annotation, TF-IDF, and writing of the report.

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